

## CHAPTER TWO

# UNDERSTANDING EXIT OPTIONS

For all our talk about buying a house for the long term, you're probably going to have to leave your first home eventually. With all the excitement of buying, many people forget to plan for the inevitable move-out—but the truth is, an average homeowner moves five to seven years after their first purchase.

Chances are, you're *not* getting a “forever home” the first time around. You'll make sacrifices when you choose a home in your price range, and those sacrifices will start to haunt your nightmares. Maybe you'll just outgrow your small home—or maybe you'll get so sick of looking at popcorn ceilings that you'll never touch a bag of popcorn again. Even if your first home is absolutely perfect, you are likely to move for business or personal reasons at some point down the line.

What's the best way to deal with the dreaded eventual move-out? While we'd love to give you tips on packing boxes and going through storage junk, we mean financially—what's the best way to move out and sell your home without losing a whole moving-truck load of money?

There are many different strategies for leaving a house behind, and those strategies are called *exit options*. One way to save your future self a thousand headaches is to think about your exit options *before* you buy your house. (It's like making an appearance at a party when you don't want to stick around for awkward conversation—you have to formulate an exit plan prior to showing up.) If you wait until a new job or personal emergency forces you to relocate, the external pressure will make for a lousy decision.

Do yourself a favor and don't assume that your first, exciting home purchase will be your last. Before you get caught up in the whirlwind of the buying process, take your exit into consideration. A well-prepared buyer